distance shipping, several investors jointly invested in commercial voyages undertaken by Chinese ships.

The Song rulers, particularly after the capital moved to Hangzhou, promoted maritime trade, sending missions across the South China Sea to South-East Asia and across the Indian Ocean to the Indian subcontinent, the Persian Gulf and even East Africa. The Song dynasty witnessed a further refinement of Chinese high culture and aesthetics. This was an age of acclaimed literati, poets and artists – painters and skilled artisans working with porcelain, wood, bronze and fine textiles. Chinese products became much sought after for their quality, and this accounts for the much expanded foreign trade during this period.

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Before the Song dynasty, Chinese merchants and ships rarely ventured beyond Indo-China and South-East Asia. Trade with India and beyond was intermediated through the maritime kingdoms of Funan and later through the Indonesian archipelago. During the Song dynasty (960–1279 CE), Chinese ships began sailing directly to the Malabar and Coromandel coasts. They were the largest of the time, with multiple decks and bulkheads. For the first time a coating of bitumen was used to waterproof the hull. A Song-era ship (1277 CE) excavated off the coast of southern China was 78 feet long and 29 feet wide, with twelve bulkheads. Major centres for shipbuilding were established in Nanjing in Jiangsu province and in Fuzhou in Fujian province. The Moroccan traveller Ibn Battuta has also described Chinese ships anchored at the port of Calicut (mentioned in Chapter 6). As we shall see in the next chapter, the giant vessels used by Admiral Zheng He for his voyages to South-East Asia, the Indian subcontinent, the Gulf and East Africa during the early part of the Ming dynasty (1368–1644) were mostly constructed in the Nanjing shipyards. Advances in astronomy and the use of the magnetic compass also enabled voyages across vast ocean spaces for the first time. Song China marks the emergence of China as a maritime power, and it retained this status under the succeeding Yuan dynasty (1279–1368 CE) and the early part of the Ming dynasty (1368–